cosmopolitan and assured – gone was the dour manner, the shabby attire. I was accosted too (eventually), and a pleasant discussion ensued, which the Chinese steered good-humouredly to the question of how to deal with entitled Westerners. Another surprise: my interlocutors all spoke effortless American English. Several had probably studied in the US. They were friendly, light, nimble. Where had humourless, stentorian, obstreperous China gone, I remember thinking.

Perhaps the most telling moments came during the conference sessions. We had been ordered to stick to ten minutes of prepared remarks – the chairs insisting they would cut us off mid-sentence if we violated the time limit. Yet, when the Chinese delegates spoke, the injunction evaporated. I slyly and then more obviously looked at my watch during my session as the Chinese presenter sailed past the ten-minute mark, with no finger-wagging from the chair. And so it went, session after session. 'The Chinese are not comfortable with English, *lah*,' one of my Southeast Asian colleagues explained, 'so they need a little more time.' I looked around the hall, wondering about the English fluency of our Cambodian, Japanese, Korean, and Vietnamese colleagues.

Our hosts were not deliberately giving the Chinese more time. It was simply that China's power had 'arrived'. It was not just the hosts. Unthinkingly, most of us in the conference room were simply acknowledging the new reality by indulging the Chinese delegation – as we would have the American not so long before. Even in 1998, China was a behemoth – I knew the raw figures as well as anyone. Here, though, was a personal, direct, live, real-time experience of Chinese power and the opening moments in the scripting of a new world order. To use the title of former US secretary of state Dean Acheson's autobiography, I was – in a very small way – 'present at the creation'.

Economic Power